



**Sanctuary Shield**

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## Protecting Children

Children are a heritage from the Lord (Psalm 127:3). Jesus issued one of the strongest warnings in Scripture regarding harm to little ones: “Whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him to have a great millstone fastened around his neck and to be drowned in the depth of the sea” (Matthew 18:6). The church is called to defend the weak and uphold justice (Psalm 82:3-4; James 1:27). Child protection is therefore not an optional add-on to security ministry — it is a core expression of biblical stewardship, love for

neighbor, and faithful witness.

In today’s legal and cultural environment, failure to protect children can result in devastating harm to victims, civil and criminal liability for the church, and irreparable damage to its testimony. This chapter outlines a comprehensive child-protection framework built on three pillars: the Two-Adult Policy, rigorous volunteer screening, and strict adherence to mandatory reporting laws (with special focus on Pennsylvania requirements as they are standard with minor variations for the 49 other states and the District of Columbia. Nevertheless, it is strongly recommended you seek the latest directives for your location’s specific laws, forms, certifications, and clearances).

### The Two-Adult Policy (Two-Deep Rule)

No child or vulnerable adult should ever be left alone with a single adult in any church program, activity, or facility. At least two unrelated, screened adults should always be present.

#### *Rationale*

- Prevents opportunities for abuse.
- Provides mutual accountability and immediate witnesses.
- Demonstrates prudent care rather than blind trust.
- Protects both children and adult volunteers from false accusations.

#### *Implementation Guidelines*

- Applies to nurseries, Sunday school, children’s church, youth groups, VBS, counseling sessions, transportation, and any one-on-one mentoring.
- “Unrelated” means not immediate family members (spouses or siblings may count as one adult only).
- If only one adult is available, the activity must be canceled or moved to a visible, open area with constant adult oversight.
- Doors to children’s areas must remain unlocked or have windows; no isolated rooms.
- Security cameras (where installed) must cover all children’s spaces in compliance with the church’s Surveillance Camera Policy.

#### *Enforcement*

Children’s Ministry leaders and the safety and security team should conduct random checks during services and events. Violations are treated as serious policy breaches and should be dealt with accordingly.

## Volunteer Screening and Background Checks

All individuals working with children or vulnerable adults must:

- Complete a written application and interview.
- Provide three references (including one from a previous church).
- Undergo a Pennsylvania State Police criminal background check (PATCH) and a Child Abuse History Clearance (ChildLine).
- For out-of-state applicants: additional FBI fingerprint-based check.
- Repeat clearances every two years (or per insurance requirements).

New volunteers may not begin service until clearances are received and approved by the Children's Ministry Director and Security Team Lead. All records are kept confidential and stored securely.

## Mandatory Reporting Requirements (Pennsylvania Law)

Pennsylvania law designates all church staff, volunteers, and leaders who have regular contact with children as mandated reporters (23 Pa.C.S. § 6311).

### Key Obligations

- Immediate report (within 24 hours, sooner if possible) to ChildLine (1-800-932-0313) or local law enforcement if you have reasonable cause to suspect abuse (physical, sexual, emotional, neglect, or exploitation).
- You do not need proof — suspicion based on observation, disclosure, or credible report is enough.
- **Reporting is not optional; failure to report is a criminal offense.**
- **The church cannot investigate or “handle it internally” in place of a report.**
- Immunity is provided for good-faith reporters; retaliation against a reporter is illegal.

### Best Practices

- Annual child-protection training for all children's and youth workers.
- Clear drop-off/pick-up procedures with photo ID verification where possible.
- Written parental consent forms for all off-site activities.
- Immediate activation of the Security Team for any custody dispute (see separate Child Custody Dispute procedure).
- Post-incident pastoral care and professional counseling referrals for victims and families.

## Protecting Testimony While Protecting Children

Transparent, compassionate, and lawful handling of child-protection matters demonstrates that the church values both grace and truth. Quick reporting, thorough documentation, and cooperation with authorities prevent the appearance of cover-up and preserve credibility. A strong child-protection program becomes part of the church's positive testimony: “This is a safe place where children are cherished and evil is confronted.”

We strongly recommend every church adopt the Two-Adult Policy immediately and continue to pray for the children entrusted to your care.

## State Law

Pennsylvania's child clearance requirements for volunteers are among the most comprehensive in the nation. They reflect a strong legislative emphasis on protecting minors in any setting involving "direct contact" (routine interaction, supervision, care, or guidance). This section compares Pennsylvania's system with other states so churches can understand their own obligations, evaluate risk, and adopt best practices that protect children while preserving testimony.

## Pennsylvania

Under the Child Protective Services Law (CPSL), all adults aged 18+ who have direct volunteer contact with children must obtain three clearances *\*before\** serving:

*Pennsylvania Clearances*

| Clearance Type                                                | Description                           | Cost      | Renewal                                         | Notes                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PA Child Abuse History Clearance (ChildLine / Act 151)</b> | Checks statewide child abuse registry | Free      | Every 5 years (60 months from oldest clearance) | Electronic application via COMPASS portal                                                                   |
| <b>PA State Police Criminal History (PATCH / Act 34)</b>      | Statewide criminal background check   | Free      | Every 5 years                                   | Electronic via epatch.pa.gov                                                                                |
| <b>FBI Criminal History Fingerprint Check (Act 114)</b>       | National fingerprint-based check      | \$22–\$27 | Every 5 years                                   | Required only if not a continuous PA resident for the past 10 years; otherwise, a signed affidavit suffices |

## Key PA Rules

1. Clearances must be on file before any service begins.
2. Applies to nurseries, Sunday school, youth groups, VBS, transportation, mentoring, etc.
3. Minors under 18 are exempt.
4. Clearances are valid for 60 months from the date of the *\*oldest\** clearance.
5. Church must keep confidential records and conduct random audits.

This three-clearance model is stricter than most states because it mandates both state-level child abuse and criminal checks plus a national fingerprint check for recent out-of-state residents.

## Comparison with Other States

Most states do not require the same level of clearances for unpaid church volunteers. Requirements are typically limited to licensed childcare facilities, schools, or foster care. Churches often follow best-practice standards recommended by insurance carriers rather than strict state mandates. Here is a high-level comparison (as of 2026):

### *State by State Comparisons*

| Category                          | States                                                                                                                                                                         | Requirements                                                                                 | Renewal Frequency | Notes                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Strict (Similar to PA)</b>     | California, New York, Michigan                                                                                                                                                 | State criminal + child abuse registry + fingerprints (Live Scan in CA)                       | 2–5 years         | CA requires Live Scan fingerprints for “regular volunteers” (>16 hrs/month) in youth-serving organizations including churches |
| <b>Moderate</b>                   | Texas, Florida, Illinois, Ohio, New Jersey                                                                                                                                     | State criminal background check + sex offender registry; child abuse check often recommended | 1–5 years         | Many require checks only for “positions of trust”; churches encouraged but not always mandated                                |
| <b>Minimal / Recommended Only</b> | Most Southern and Midwestern states (e.g., Alabama, Georgia, Indiana, Missouri)                                                                                                | No statewide mandate for church volunteers                                                   | N/A (voluntary)   | Insurance carriers strongly recommend annual or biennial national criminal checks                                             |
| <b>Universal / Anyone</b>         | Alaska, Arizona, California, Delaware, Hawaii, Iowa, Maine, Missouri, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New Mexico, Oklahoma, Oregon, Rhode Island, Tennessee, Vermont, West Virginia | Any person who suspects abuse must report; background checks encouraged for volunteers       | Varies            | Focus is on mandatory reporting rather than pre-service clearances                                                            |

## General Trends Across All 50 States

- Paid staff in child-related roles almost always require background checks.
- Volunteers are rarely under the same strict mandates as in Pennsylvania unless the church operates licensed childcare.
- Common best practice (followed by most churches regardless of state law): National criminal background check + sex offender registry + reference checks.
- Fingerprints are rarely required for volunteers outside of PA, CA, and a few others.
- Renewal ranges from annual (insurance-driven) to every 5 years.
- Out-of-state residents often trigger additional FBI checks in stricter states.

## Practical Recommendations for Any Church (Regardless of State)

1. Adopt the highest reasonable standard — even if your state does not mandate it. Pennsylvania’s model is an excellent benchmark for protecting children and testimony.

2. Use a national vendor (e.g., MinistrySafe, Protect My Ministry, or Shepherd's Watch) for comprehensive checks that include county, state, national, and sex offender registries.
3. Combine with the Two-Adult Policy — no child ever alone with one adult.
4. Document everything — maintain confidential files and track renewal dates.
5. Train annually — pair clearances with mandated reporter training.
6. Consult your insurance carrier — many require or incentivize background checks to maintain coverage.

These safeguards are an act of prudent love. By screening every adult who serves children, the church fulfills its duty to “defend the weak and the fatherless” (Psalm 82:3-4) and guards the testimony that Church (and every faithful congregation) is a haven for God’s little ones.

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